Silent Evasion: Measuring the Adversarial Fragility of Small Language Models Used for Security Triage

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ABSTRACT

Security teams often use language models (AI text classifiers) to sort incoming emails and text messages. The model decides whether a message is *malicious* (harmful or dangerous) or *benign* (safe and normal) before a human analyst reviews it. In this paper, we study what happens when an attacker makes small, careful text edits (known as perturbations) to bypass the classifier. We show that evasion rates can only be measured accurately under a *conditional* testing rule: researchers must only attack messages that the model originally caught, verify each original message again during testing, and limit the attacker to a realistic edit budget per sample.

We test this method on three open, lightweight language models (1.7 billion to 3.8 billion parameters) without extra fine-tuning (zero-shot) on phishing emails and SMS spam (smishing). We test 2,079 caught messages using 8,047 model queries under a 15% total edit budget. At first glance, the models appear quite resistant to simple edits. Small character changes (like typos or look-alike letters) flip only 0.0–5.0% of caught messages. Simple word swaps flip only 1.0–5.1% while modifying about half as many letters.

However, a more targeted search changes the picture. When we use a saliency-guided word attack (ranking word replacements by their actual impact on the model's decision), the attack success rate rises to 4.6%, compared to 2.7% for random word swaps. This guided attack achieves 46 flips across 1,001 attacks, averaging 23 model queries per message. In direct paired comparisons on the exact same messages, the saliency attack flips 33 messages that random edits miss, while random edits flip only 7 that saliency misses (exact McNemar $p = 4 \times 10^{-5}$). A similar but smaller gap appears between word and character edits (26 versus 10, $p = 0.011$). This demonstrates that model vulnerability is concentrated in a few key words rather than spread evenly across the vocabulary. Evasion rates depend heavily on the quality of the attacker's search strategy.

Two other key findings help interpret these numbers. First, text edits do not transfer well across different models. When we test saved edits against other models, only 0.9% of caught messages flip off the diagonal. Second, continuous probability scores (the model's internal confidence) do not always match the final generated text decision. The two readouts agree on 941 of 1,001 rows, matching perfectly for one model but diverging on another. We report final text decisions throughout and treat this gap as an important measurement finding. For defenses, cleaning look-alike characters stops all character-level evasions, but has little effect on word-level swaps (7.5% to 6.9%). Adjusting decision cutoffs (re-thresholding) to maintain a 5% false-alarm budget can actually increase evasions for models with uncalibrated probability scores.

Our main practical takeaway is that with small edit budgets, the primary limitation of small triage models is basic classification accuracy rather than susceptibility to random text edits. Furthermore, attack success rates must always be reported with their exact denominator (sample count), a statistical confidence interval, and the specific search method used. A result of 0 out of 188 is an upper limit of 2.0%, not proof of absolute security. We release all frozen datasets, attack code, and individual sample records to support reproducible security evaluations.

CCS CONCEPTS

• **Security and privacy** → **Intrusion/anomaly detection and malware mitigation**; • **Computing methodologies** → *Natural language processing*.

KEYWORDS

adversarial text, small language models, phishing detection, smishing, security triage, evaluation methodology

1 INTRODUCTION

A phishing email that reaches a security analyst has usually passed several initial spam filters. Often, the next security layer is a small language model (an AI text classifier). The model makes a fast, automated decision: is this message malicious (harmful) or benign (safe)? Small open models with 1 to 4 billion parameters are popular for this job. They run on a single standard GPU, can be hosted privately inside an organization, and require no special training examples [7, 13]. However, an attacker can change their message to bypass this filter.

This paper tests how much small text edits (called perturbations) help an attacker evade detection. We limit the attacker to simple changes that a human reader would easily overlook. These changes include look-alike characters (such as replacing Latin letters with similar Cyrillic letters), tiny typos, and simple synonyms. The total changes are kept under a strict 15% edit budget per message. We measure how often these edits cause the model's decision (verdict) to flip from *malicious* to *benign*.

Why the denominator is crucial. An attack success rate (ASR) is meaningless without knowing its denominator (the total number of tested samples). In security research, two different denominators are often used. The first counts all malicious messages. The second counts only the messages that the clean model correctly identified as malicious before the attack. The second definition is what truly matters for evasion: if a model never caught a message in the first place, modifying that message cannot count as a successful attack flip [10]. Therefore, we only attack messages that the clean model originally flagged as malicious. We re-test every original message during the attack process to confirm this label, and we report the baseline catch rate alongside every ASR.

Contributions.

(1) **A strict, reproducible evasion evaluation protocol** (§3): We use a conditional denominator with re-verified original messages, an exact Levenshtein edit distance budget shared across all edits, identical prompts between baseline and attack phases, and public sample records so every result can be verified.
(2) **An empirical evaluation of three small open models** (§5): Testing 2,079 caught messages across 8,047 model queries resulted in 40 total decision flips. We test character-level and word-level edits under the same budget, provide 95% confidence intervals for every row, and evaluate a saliency-guided attack that spends more queries to rank word importance (§6).
(3) **A paired comparison between edit types** (§5.7): Word substitutions flip more decisions than character noise while requiring roughly half as many edits (26 versus 10 sample-specific flips, $p = 0.011$). In addition, ranking word swaps by model saliency flips more messages than random word swaps under the same budget (33 versus 7, $p = 4 \times 10^{-5}$). Pairing tests on the exact same messages provides an honest comparison.
(4) **Low transferability across models** (§7): Replaying saved text edits across different models flips almost no samples off the diagonal. Transfer rates remain low overall. The edits appear specific to individual models rather than universal. Guided edits transfer slightly better than random edits, but remain ineffective as portable attacks.
(5) **Analysis of model decision boundaries**: The model with the highest attack success rate is the one operating closest to its decision boundary, not the least accurate model overall. Conversely, a model that marks almost everything as malicious appears artificially robust simply because its classification rule rarely changes.
(6) **A clear negative result**: Under a 15% edit budget, random edits rarely fool these models. For practical deployments, the real concern is initial detection accuracy rather than vulnerability to simple random edits.

Scope and limitations. We do not evaluate white-box attacks with full access to model internal weights, nor do we evaluate adaptive attackers who know the defense beforehand. Our saliency search selects words using model feedback, but it also uses a larger dictionary than the random word baseline. Therefore, the gap between them is not due to word ordering alone (§6). An ablation study in §6.1 isolates these factors and shows their individual impact on identical messages. Across the two random attacks, we observe 40 flips in 2,079 messages across 8,047 queries. Because these flip counts are small, the confidence intervals are wide, and we focus on general trends rather than minor numerical differences.

2 RELATED WORK

Language models as email and SMS detectors. Using pre-trained language models without fine-tuning (zero-shot classification) is now a standard baseline for security triage. Rojas-Galeano tested models on SpamAssassin without extra training. They reported an F1 score of 90% for Flan-T5 on short emails and 95% for GPT-4 on summarized emails [13]. Eilertsen et al. tested zero-shot and few-shot prompts for phishing detection. They found mixed accuracy across models and questioned if decisions rely on model knowledge or prompt examples [3]. Koide et al. designed a detector using email headers and bodies. They reported 99.70% accuracy with GPT-4 [7]. Wang et al. added external web context to SMS triage inside an agent pipeline, achieving 98.8% overall accuracy [17]. Thapa et al. studied small language models and observed that rewritten emails lower detection performance [15]. Our study focuses on measurement discipline rather than model architecture. We keep the detector and prompt constant, applying careful accounting rules to measure how text edits change the verdict.

Attacking security text filters. Shafee et al. generated plausible text to attack threat intelligence pipelines. They found that evasion misled classifiers, producing a 75% false-positive rate when ChatGPT-4o acted as the detector [14]. Kulkarni et al. generated adversarial phishing pages. They observed that small detectors failed, while vision-language models proved more resilient [8]. In our setting, we study raw message text rather than web pages. Our adversary makes small edits rather than generating new text from scratch. This matches the real constraints of an attacker who wants users to read the message.

Text perturbation techniques and budgets. Character-level attacks change individual letters. DeepWordBug introduced typos and letter swaps [4], while HotFlip formalized gradient character flips [2]. Word-level attacks replace whole words while preserving meaning. TextFooler searches synonyms greedily [6], and PWWS ranks words by probability changes (saliency) [12]. The TextAttack library organizes these methods into standard goals, constraints, and transformations [10]. In this paper, we evaluate two main search strengths. The first is a random draw over a small synonym table. This represents a simple adversary and serves as a lower bound on evasion rates. The second is a guided attack that ranks word swaps by their measured effect on the model (§6). In §6.1, we also test TextFooler's leave-one-out word ranking as a reference arm. We use PWWS and TextFooler to define search logic rather than to compare numerical results directly.

Cross-model transfer and evaluation methodology. Yuan et al. showed that adversarial text often transfers across different neural models, and they built ensembles to target multiple models together [18]. He et al. extracted model parameters to build transferable attacks against a target system [5]. These studies motivate our cross-model transfer matrix in §7. In our tests, black-box perturbations found on one model rarely transfer to another. Our adversary uses a bounded local search rather than learning global transfer directions. On statistical methodology, Carlini et al. demonstrated that many adversarial robustness evaluations contain flaws and proposed standard practices for threat models [1]. Zimmermann et al. used active tests to reveal weaknesses in 11 of 13 published defenses [19]. Recent research also highlights the importance of exact confidence intervals for robustness certificates [16]. We follow these rigorous practices. Every evasion rate in this paper reports its numerator, its denominator, and an exact Wilson interval [**?**].

3 THREAT MODEL AND MEASUREMENT PROTOCOL

3.1 Adversary

The attacker controls the message text and nothing else: no access to weights, gradients, logits or the detector's code, and no ability to retrain it. The attacker additionally wants the message to remain readable, so the edit budget is bounded: at most 15% of the message's units (characters for the character-level attack, whitespace tokens for the word-level attack) may change, and the change is measured, not estimated.

Two access levels, reported separately. Not every attack in this paper assumes the same interface, and the paper never pools them. *Verdict access* returns the one-word generated answer: malicious or benign, one bit per query. That is what a spammer probing a filter receives, and it is the oracle for the character and random-word attacks (§5). *Probability access* additionally exposes $P(\text{malicious})$ — here by scoring the two permitted answer tokens — and only the saliency-guided attack uses it (§6), because a ranking needs a number and one bit per candidate cannot produce one. Every row in every table records which channel produced it, the two channels are never mixed in a single comparison, and the disagreement between them is itself reported (§9). The ablation of §6.1 holds the oracle fixed across arms precisely so that the cost of dropping from probability access to verdict access is measured rather than assumed.

The verdict-only adversary is a deliberately weak one, and its ASR is a lower bound for that reason as well. A white-box attacker with logit access, an embedding-space attack, or a saliency-guided word search would do better. The point of a weak adversary is that a flip under it is unambiguously bad news for the detector: nothing exotic happened, the message simply stopped looking suspicious.

3.2 The four rules that make an ASR quotable

Rule 1 — conditional denominator, re-queried. Only messages the clean model classified *malicious* are attacked. The original text is queried again inside the attack run instead of trusting the baseline label, and a sample whose original is no longer read as malicious is *excluded* from the denominator rather than counted as a failed attack. In our runs this happened 52 times, and each exclusion is recorded with its reason. The 52 split into exactly two kinds, and the split is not the one an earlier draft reported. Forty-three are samples the saliency attack's probability route read as benign on the original — all of them on Qwen2.5-3B, which is a channel artefact discussed in §9. The other nine are word-attack samples whose perturbation came out identical to the original, so no edit was measured and there was nothing to score. No original was dropped for any other reason: the generator route never re-read a baseline-caught message as benign, so the character and saliency runs on the other two models exclude nothing at all.

Rule 2 — the same prompt on both sides. The baseline and the attack call the identical message template, including the sample's own task description, so an e-mail is never scored with the SMS prompt. A baseline-versus-attack comparison across different prompts measures the prompt.

Rule 3 — one shared budget, exact distance. The 15% budget is a single allowance for the whole perturbation, not one per operation, and the perturbation rate is the exact Levenshtein distance divided by the length of the original. Both details are load-bearing. Giving each operation its own allowance let the real rate reach 22% while the paper called it 15%; and estimating the distance from a 'difflib' opcode tally reported 204 edits for 56 deleted characters on a repetitive message, because 'difflib' does not compute a minimal edit script.

Rule 4 — name the similarity you actually computed. We report word-set Jaccard overlap and call it Jaccard. No semantic-similarity model is used anywhere in this study, so no BERTScore is claimed. For the character attack we additionally note that Jaccard is the wrong instrument: a homoglyph substitution changes the token, so word-set overlap collapses even though a human reads the same message.

3.3 Perturbations

Character level. Four operations share the budget: homoglyph substitution (Latin 'a', 'e', 'o', 'p', 'c', 'x', 'y', 'i', 's' replaced by Cyrillic codepoints), random deletion, random insertion of lowercase letters, and adjacent-position swap (costing two edits).

Word level. Four operations share the budget: replacement of a word by one of its listed synonyms from a hand-written 14-entry table, word deletion, word duplication, and word swap. The synonym table is deliberately small, which weakens the attack and strengthens the negative result.

How many attempts, and what that costs. The two random attacks give each sample up to three independent attempts with a per-sample seeded random generator, stopping at the first flip, so a message can cost one to four queries: one for the re-queried original plus one per attempt. On the recorded runs that comes to 3.9 queries per message and 8,047 queries for the 2,079 attacked messages — the number of messages and the number of queries are different quantities and are reported separately throughout. The saliency attack is not attempt-based: it probes every candidate position once and then re-queries after each accepted edit, 22.9 queries per message on average. The earlier draft of this paragraph said "one attempt per sample", which the per-sample records contradict; the attempt column in every row is the correction.

Every attempt's perturbed text, verdict, edit count and rate is written to the per-sample CSV, so the tables can be rebuilt without the model.

3.4 Statistics

An ASR of k flips out of n attacks is a binomial proportion. We report the 95% Wilson score interval, which stays inside $[0, 1]$ and, crucially, does not collapse at the boundary: a row with $k = 0$ of $n = 188$ has upper bound 2.0%, not 0%. A percentile bootstrap over the same rows (10,000 resamples, fixed seed) is computed as a cross-check and agrees with Wilson wherever $k > 0$; where $k = 0$ the bootstrap degenerates to $[0, 0]$ and we quote Wilson instead. The interval covers sampling variability over *messages*, not variation of the perturbation seed; estimating the latter requires a second run over the same samples, which is what the seed sweep below does.

Seed variation. The intervals above cover variation over messages, not over the perturbation generator. The runner therefore takes `--seed` and a sweep driver (`src/run_seed_sweep.py`) reruns one arm at several seeds, so the seed-to-seed spread can be reported next to the sampling interval rather than absorbed into it. The sweep is implemented; its cells are not part of the numbers in this version, and §9 lists that as a gap rather than implying the intervals cover it.

4 EXPERIMENTAL SETUP

Data. Two triage tasks. *SMS smishing* uses the UCI SMS Spam Collection (5,574 messages, 747 labelled spam), with spam treated as malicious. The task label is therefore "SMS spam/smishing"; the collection's spam class is dominated by scam and prize messages rather than by credential-harvesting links, and we flag this as a construct-validity limit rather than hide it. *Phishing e-mail* uses the `zefang-liu/phishing-email-dataset` text column, filtered to messages between 16 and 3,000 characters and balanced-sampled to 1,000 benign and 1,000 phishing rows with a fixed seed.

Splits. The evaluation split is balanced and frozen: 200 benign and 200 malicious rows per task, 800 rows in total, drawn with seed 42. The split is byte-identical across every run, and its fingerprint is asserted by the artefact's bootstrap step, so a run that uses different data fails before it can report a number. Attacks are launched on the caught subset *of this evaluation split*, which is a within-sample design: the same 800 rows supply both the baseline and the attack set. We state this because it means the ASR is not an out-of-sample estimate; it is a conditional measurement on the messages the model got right, which is what Rule 1 defines.

Models. Three open instruction-tuned models, all quantisation-free at inference: Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct, SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct and Phi-3.5-mini-instruct (3.8B). A fourth model, Llama-3.2-3B-Instruct, was planned but is gated behind a licence acceptance and is not part of any number reported here.

Inference. All models are served behind one OpenAI-compatible endpoint and queried with the same message list. Generation is greedy (temperature 0), capped at 8 new tokens, with a single-word answer parser that returns malicious, benign, or *unparsed*; unparsed verdicts are counted separately and never guessed. In the runs reported here, no verdict failed to parse. Models are loaded in half precision on one T4 GPU with automatic device placement.

Compute and cost. One full run — clean baseline on 800 rows for three models, construction of the attack set, and both attack modes for all three models — takes 37.1 minutes on a single free-tier T4. The reporting step is a separate pass over the per-sample CSVs and runs on CPU.

Evaluation pipeline. Figure 1 shows the full pipeline. A message is classified by the model. If the verdict is malicious, the message enters the attack set. The perturbation engine applies edits and re-queries the model. The results are then evaluated for transfer and defense robustness.

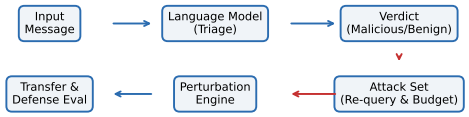


Figure 1: The evaluation pipeline. A clean message is classified by the model. If the verdict is malicious, the message enters the attack set. The perturbation engine applies edits under budget and re-queries the model. The results are then evaluated for transfer and defense robustness.

Reproducibility. Splits, prompt, decoding and per-sample perturbation seeds are fixed. The study was run twice end to end (two independent GPU sessions); per-sample comparison of the two runs, joined on sample id, gives identical attacked ids and identical success flags in all six result files, with differences only in empty cells of the excluded rows. The second run is the one whose outputs are reported here.

5 RESULTS

5.1 Clean baseline, and what it already tells us

Table 1 is the clean zero-shot baseline. Two rows matter more than the accuracy column.

Phi-3.5-mini is a conservative detector on e-mail. Its precision is high (0.896) but it misses 80 of the 200 phishing messages, a catch rate of 60.0%. It is the model that leaves most malicious mail in the analyst's queue before any attack happens.

SmolLM2-1.7B is a degenerate detector. It reaches a catch rate of 98.5% on phishing e-mail, but its precision is 0.510 and its confusion matrix shows 189 false positives against 11 true negatives on the benign class: it calls nearly every message malicious. A detector that says *malicious* almost always is trivially hard to flip towards *benign*, and every robustness number for it has to be read against that fact.

Qwen2.5-3B is the strongest and most balanced classifier of the three (F1 0.923 on e-mail, 0.857 on SMS).

5.2 Character-level evasion

Table 2 reports the character-level attack. Of 1,044 caught messages attacked, 12 flipped: an aggregate of 1.1%. Per row the ASR lies between 0.0% and 5.0%, and under a 15% budget the mean perturbation actually spent was 13.3–13.6% of characters, with no row above the budget (maximum 13.6%).

The highest row is Phi-3.5-mini on phishing e-mail: 6 flips in 120 attacked messages, 5.0% (95% CI 2.3–10.5). This is the model with the lowest catch rate on that task. The model that catches 95.5% of e-mail (Qwen2.5-3B) flips once in 191 attacks, and on SMS it flips zero times in 188 attempts. A zero is reported as a bounded measurement, not a proof: the Wilson upper bound for that row is 2.0%.

Table 1: Clean zero-shot baseline on the frozen 800-row evaluation split (400 rows per task, 200 malicious). "Catch" is recall on the malicious class and is the denominator every ASR in this paper is conditional on.

Task	Model	Acc.	Prec.	Rec.	F1	TP/FP	Catch
SMS smishing	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	0.772	0.751	0.815	0.782	163/54	81.5%
	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	0.843	0.787	0.940	0.857	188/51	94.0%
	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	0.525	0.514	0.925	0.661	185/175	92.5%
Phishing email	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	0.765	0.895	0.600	0.719	120/14	60.0%
	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	0.920	0.892	0.955	0.923	191/23	95.5%
	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	0.520	0.510	0.985	0.672	197/189	98.5%

Table 2: Character-level evasion under a 15% edit budget. ASR is flips / samples attacked, where only samples the clean model classified malicious are attacked and each original is re-queried. CI is a 95% Wilson interval.

Task	Model	Attacked	Flips	ASR	95% CI	Pert.	Jacc.	Catch
SMS smishing	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	163	3	1.8%	0.6–5.3	13.3%	0.328	81.5%
	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	188	0	0.0%	0.0–2.0	13.5%	0.322	94.0%
	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	185	1	0.5%	0.1–3.0	13.5%	0.317	92.5%
Phishing email	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	120	6	5.0%	2.3–10.5	13.5%	0.322	60.0%
	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	191	1	0.5%	0.1–2.9	13.6%	0.303	95.5%
	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	197	1	0.5%	0.1–2.8	13.4%	0.311	98.5%

5.3 Word-level evasion

Table 3 applies the same budget to whole words. Of 1,035 caught messages, 28 flipped — more than twice the character-level count — while changing only 6.2–9.2% of words, roughly half the unit budget the character attack spent. Word-set Jaccard stays at 0.916–0.950, i.e. the messages are 92–95% word-identical to what the model had already caught.

The ranking changes. The character attack leaves Qwen2.5-3B on SMS at zero flips; the word attack flips 6 of 186 (3.2%, CI 1.5–6.9). Word-level changes carry semantic weight that a single glyph does not: replacing a suspicious verb with a neutral synonym, or deleting the word that carried the urgency, moves a verdict that typo noise does not.

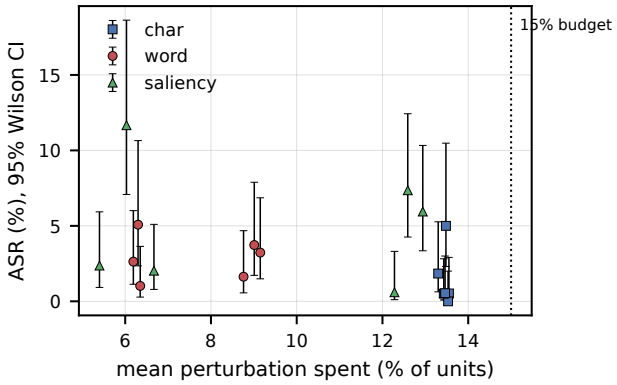


Figure 2: Each point is one (model, task, attack) cell: the perturbation actually spent on the horizontal axis, the ASR with its 95% Wilson interval on the vertical one. The dotted line is the 15% budget. Points to the left of a vertical pair are the same amount of visible change bought at half the unit cost – the word attack's advantage is horizontal as well as vertical.

5.4 Budget accounting

Table 4 is the accounting check, and Figure 2 is the same accounting drawn instead of summed: one point per model, task and attack, spent budget on the horizontal axis. Both modes stay inside the shared budget, and the word attack reaches a comparable number of flips with about half the fraction of units changed. That asymmetry is the paper's main empirical point: for these models, *what* is changed matters more than *how much*.

5.5 What predicts fragility

Across the six model–task cells, the ASR orders by proximity to the decision boundary rather than by accuracy. Phi-3.5-mini has the highest character ASR on e-mail (5.0%) and the weakest recall there (0.600). SmolLM2-1.7B has the highest recall (0.985) and among the lowest ASR (0.5% on e-mail) — because its decision rule is nearly constant. A small perturbation either does nothing or, in the case of the 2 of 196 word attacks that flipped it, pushes a barely-considered verdict across the line. Neither behaviour is robustness in the sense a deployment cares about.

5.6 Interval discipline

Figure 3 collects all twelve random-attack cells and the three saliency cells in one panel, with the interval drawn on every bar, so the comparison below can be read at a glance rather than row by row.

Because the flip counts are small, we do not rank models on point estimates. Of the twelve pairs of rows sharing a task and

Table 3: Word-level evasion under the same 15% budget (synonym swap, deletion, duplication, swap). Jaccard is word-set overlap; no semantic-similarity model is used anywhere in this study.

Task	Model	Attacked	Flips	ASR	95% CI	Pert.	Jacc.	Catch
SMS smishing	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	161	6	3.7%	1.7–7.9	9.0%	0.918	81.5%
	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	186	6	3.2%	1.5–6.9	9.2%	0.916	94.0%
	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	184	3	1.6%	0.6–4.7	8.8%	0.916	92.5%
Phishing email	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	118	6	5.1%	2.4–10.7	6.3%	0.945	60.0%
	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	190	5	2.6%	1.1–6.0	6.2%	0.950	95.5%
	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	196	2	1.0%	0.3–3.6	6.3%	0.948	98.5%

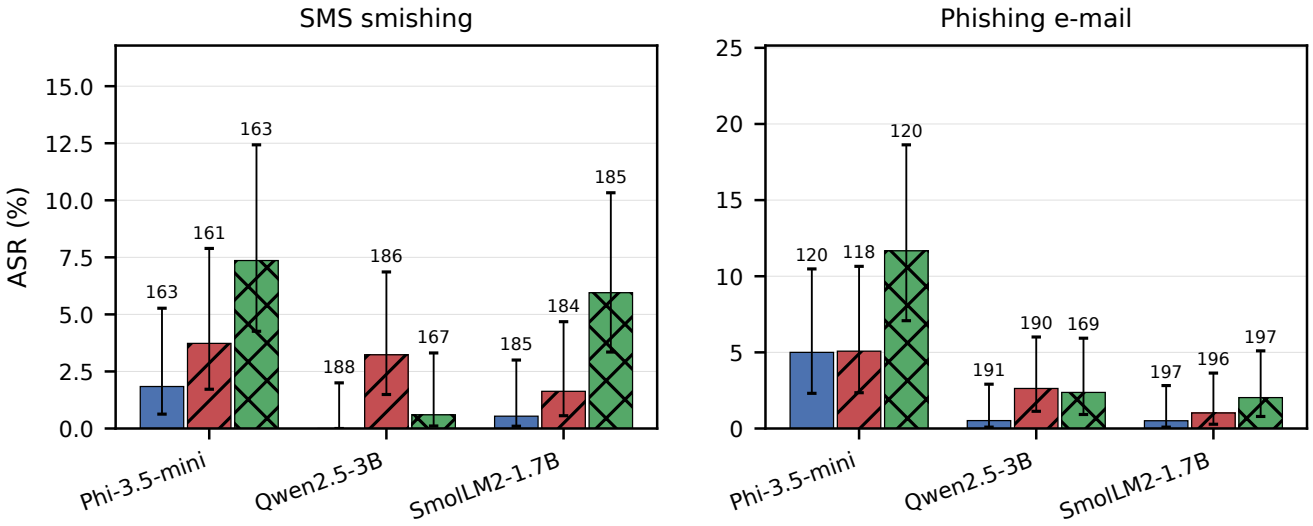


Figure 3: Attack success rate per model, task and attack mode, with 95% Wilson intervals on the flip count. Solid blue bars are the character attack, hatched red bars the word attack, and green cross-hatched bars the saliency-guided word attack of §6, which is drawn here for comparison but costs 22.9 model queries per message against 3.9 for the two random attacks, so the bars are not a cost-matched comparison. The number above each interval is the denominator: the messages that model had caught on the clean text and that were therefore attacked. A cell at zero is drawn with its interval, not as a point at the origin, because 0/188 is a bounded measurement rather than a proof of robustness.

Table 4: Edit budget actually spent, by attack mode. The budget is one shared 15% allowance per sample; the measured rate is the exact Levenshtein distance divided by the original length (characters or words).

Mode	Samples	Flips	Mean pert.	Max pert.
Character	1044	12	13.5%	13.6%
Word	1035	28	7.6%	9.2%
Saliency	1001	46	9.3%	12.9%
Total		86		

one of the two random attack modes, 9 of 12 have intervals that overlap by more than half the narrower interval, so within-task ordering is suggestive rather than established. The exceptions are informative: under the character attack on phishing e-mail, Phi-3.5-mini's interval overlaps Qwen2.5-3B's by 21.3% and SmolLM2-1.7B's by 18.7% of the narrower width — the one separation that survives the uncertainty is exactly the boundary-proximity effect of §5.5.

What the intervals do establish is magnitude, and the magnitude depends on the search. No random-perturbation cell exceeds 10.7% at its upper bound; the saliency-guided cells of §6 reach 18.6%. The claim "under a 15% edit budget a random perturbation leaves these models close to robust" survives the uncertainty; the claim "model A is more robust than model B" does not, for most pairs, and neither claim extends to a better search.

5.7 Is the difference between the two modes real?

Comparing a 3.7% cell with a 1.8% cell as if they were independent samples is the wrong test: both attacks ran on the *same* messages,

so the flips are paired, and the pairing is what makes a small difference measurable. We pair the per-sample outcomes on the message identifier and report the discordant counts, an exact McNemar test, and a paired bootstrap of the risk difference over messages.

Pairing the two attacks on the messages both of them attacked, the word attack flips 26 messages the character attack leaves alone, and the character attack flips 10 that the word attack leaves alone (exact McNemar $p = 0.011$ over the pooled discordant counts). Per cell, 1 of 6 show a significant paired difference at $p < 0.05$: SMS smishing/Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct. The rest are underpowered rather than contradictory, and the pooled test is a description of the direction because the cells reuse the same messages across models.

The honest reading is narrower than the raw table suggests. The direction is consistent — word-level edits flip more messages than character-level ones in five of six cells and never fewer — but only one cell is separately significant, because there the character attack flipped nothing at all. What survives is a pooled statement about this corpus and these three models, not a per-model ranking, and the interval widths in Table 5 say the same thing.

6 WHERE IS THE MODEL FRAGILE? A SALIENCY-GUIDED WORD ATTACK

The word attack of §5 draws its substitution uniformly at random from a small synonym table. It answers "does *any* word-level edit break the model" and leaves the distribution of fragility unmeasured: a flip caused by deleting the word *urgent* and a flip caused by replacing the word *the* are the same event in that accounting. This section asks the sharper question, and pays for the answer in queries.

Method. We implement the ordering of PWWS [12]. For a message x that the model reads as malicious with probability p_0, a content word i and a candidate replacement w, let $p_{i,w} = P(\text{malicious} \mid x \text{ with word } i \text{ replaced by } w)$ be measured with the same prompt. Word saliency and the substitution priority are

$$S_i = p_0 - p_{i,w}, \qquad \phi_{i,w} = \alpha \tilde{S}_i + (1 - \alpha)\, p_{i,w}, \tag{1}$$

where $\tilde{S}_i$ is S_i divided by the largest saliency in the message and $\alpha = 0.5$. Substitutions are applied greedily in descending ϕ; after each accepted edit the verdict is re-queried, and the attack stops at the first flip or when the shared 15% word budget is exhausted.

The normalisation of S is not cosmetic. With raw saliency and $\alpha = 0.5$, $\phi_{i,w} = \frac{1}{2}(p_0 - p_{i,w}) + \frac{1}{2}p_{i,w} = \frac{1}{2}p_0$ for *every* candidate: the ranking collapses to a constant, and the greedy loop then applies substitutions in the order the words happen to appear in the message. Because p_0 is common to all candidates, only the scale of S matters, and the scale is exactly what the normalisation fixes. Our first implementation of this module had that defect; the unit test that now guards it (`tests/check_saliency.py`) asserts that a high-saliency word outranks a neutral one at $\alpha = 0.5$.

Candidate replacements. Two sources, recorded per substitution: a curated security lexicon (66 entries: *verify* → *confirm/validate*, *prize* → *award/reward*, …) and WordNet [9] synonyms ordered by lemma frequency. Frequency ordering matters more than it looks: WordNet's third sense of a word is where synonyms stop being paraphrases (*tone* → *timber*), and a substitution like that would be counted as semantics-preserving when it is not. Multi-word replacements are excluded so that the 15% budget counts words and nothing else. Candidates are capped at two per position and twelve positions per message, which is what keeps the query cost bounded.

Two verdict channels. This attack needs a number, not a paragraph: at every candidate it asks the endpoint for $P(\text{malicious})$, obtained by scoring the two permitted answer tokens in one forward pass. The other two attacks read the model's generated one-word reply instead. Those are two readouts of the same model, and comparing their ASRs without checking that they agree would be comparing a ruler with a scale. Every stored saliency row is therefore re-scored through the generation route, and Table 6 reports the generation verdict; the artefact keeps both columns and the probability-route count, and we do not treat a disagreement between them as a bug to be tuned away — it is a fact about the model.

The probability route also has a failure mode worth recording, because it is silent. The answer tokens are chosen per tokenizer, and Phi-3.5 encodes " malicious" as three tokens whose first element is the bare whitespace marker that " benign" also begins with. Scoring the first token of each answer therefore compares the space against itself: both logits are identical, $P(\text{malicious}) = 0.5$ for every message, and a saliency attack built on it finds nothing to rank and no flip to report. The endpoint now skips the shared prefix, and raises rather than returning a constant when the two answers cannot be separated. The saliency numbers for that model in this version come from the corrected scoring; its earlier all-zero result was an artefact.

Query accounting. Unlike the random attack, this one costs a measured number of model calls: roughly two per probed position, plus one verification per accepted edit. Probabilities come from a dedicated endpoint that scores the two permitted answer tokens in a single forward pass over the prompt, batched across candidates; the per-sample count is stored with the result, so the comparison in Table 6 is between attacks whose cost is on the record. The asymmetry is real but smaller than an earlier draft of this paragraph claimed. The random attack is not one draw per sample: it re-queries every original and spends one query per attempt, up to three, which is 3.9 queries per message and 8,047 queries for the 2,079 messages it attacks. The saliency attack spends 22.9 per message — 22,964 queries for 1,001 messages, six times as many calls for 1.6 times as many flips. The paper therefore does not claim equal cost, and it no longer claims the random attack was capped at one draw.

What the comparison isolates, and what it does not. Three things change between Table 6's two rows at once: the *ordering* (uniform draw versus saliency), the *candidate set* (a 14-entry hand-written table versus a security lexicon plus WordNet), and the *oracle* (a one-bit verdict versus $P(\text{malicious})$). The table therefore supports only the combination: saliency-ordered substitution over a security vocabulary breaks more messages per unit of edit than a uniform draw over a small table. It does not show that ordering alone is responsible, and it cannot say what the probability access is worth. §6.1 specifies the experiment that separates the three.

Table 5: Paired comparison of two attack modes on the same messages. Only the discordant counts carry information about the difference: A-only flips happened under the first mode and not the second, B-only the reverse. The p-value is an exact McNemar test (binomial on the discordant counts); the interval is a percentile bootstrap over messages of the paired risk difference.

A vs B	Task	Model	Paired	A flips	B flips	Risk diff.	95% CI	A/B only	p
saliency vs word	Phishing email	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	118	14	6	+6.8	+1.7 to +11.9	9/1	0.021
saliency vs word	Phishing email	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	169	4	1	+1.8	-0.6 to +4.7	4/1	0.375
saliency vs word	Phishing email	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	196	3	2	+0.5	-1.0 to +2.0	2/1	1.000
saliency vs word	SMS smishing	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	161	12	6	+3.7	+0.6 to +7.4	7/1	0.070
saliency vs word	SMS smishing	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	167	1	1	+0.0	-1.8 to +1.8	1/1	1.000
saliency vs word	SMS smishing	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	184	11	3	+4.3	+1.1 to +8.2	10/2	0.039
word vs char	Phishing email	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	118	6	6	+0.0	-5.1 to +5.1	5/5	1.000
word vs char	Phishing email	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	190	5	1	+2.1	+0.0 to +4.7	5/1	0.219
word vs char	Phishing email	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	196	2	1	+0.5	-1.0 to +2.5	2/1	1.000
word vs char	SMS smishing	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	161	6	3	+1.9	-1.2 to +5.0	5/2	0.453
word vs char	SMS smishing	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	186	6	0	+3.2	+1.1 to +5.9	6/0	0.031
word vs char	SMS smishing	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	184	3	1	+1.1	-1.1 to +3.3	3/1	0.625

At the same word budget, the random attack flips 28 of 1035 caught messages (2.7%) and the saliency attack flips 46 of 1001 (4.6%). Each saliency-attacked message costs a mean of 23 model queries. The random word attack is not a single draw either: it re-queries every original and spends one query per attempt, so its 1,035 messages cost 3,927 queries, 3.8 each. The saliency attacker buys its extra flips with about 6.1 times as many calls, and that price is part of the claim, not a footnote to it. The saliency attack also edits MORE, not less: 9.3% of words against 7.6% for the random attack. Normalising by the budget actually spent, it buys 0.493 of a flip per percent of words edited against 0.355, so the advantage is real but smaller than the raw ASR ratio. Both numbers are pooled over different candidate vocabularies and, after the exclusions, over different message sets, so the denominator is 1,001 for the saliency attack and 1,035 for the random one; the paired comparison of Section 5.7 is the only place where the two are measured on the same messages. Pooled query accounting, kept separate from the message count because the two are different numbers: the character attack sends 1,044 caught messages in 4,120 queries, the word attack 1,035 in 3,927, so the random attacks together send 2,079 messages in 8,047 queries (3.9 each), and the saliency attack sends 1,001 messages in 22,964 queries (22.9 each).

6.1 A matched-vocabulary, matched-budget ablation

Table 6 cannot attribute its difference to any single cause, because ordering, candidate set and oracle all change together. The ablation below holds two of the three fixed in every comparison, so each contrast has one explanation. It is implemented in `src/ablation_commons.py`, exercised by `tests/check_ablation.py`, and run; its contrasts are Table 7 and the paragraph that discusses it, both generated from `results/ablation_contrasts.csv`. It is an ablation on a matched subsample, not on the full attack set, and every count it reports is paired on the messages the two arms share.

One probe phase, then a difference in policy. Every arm attacks the same messages, with the same candidate set, and pays the same probe cost before it edits anything: one query for the original, then one query per single substitution candidate, capped identically at the same number of calls per message for every arm (24 in the configuration the runner reports, and the cap it used travels with every row). The reported cells are the first 400 eligible messages of each model, and the cap never bound: the largest eligible set is 382 messages (smollm2-1.7b), so every arm attacks exactly the messages the attack tables report on, and an arm differs from another only in policy. The probe results are retained and only the *policy* differs — what the arm does with those measurements. Matching the budget by construction rather than by assumption is the point: a random-order arm pays exactly the $1 + |C|$ calls a saliency arm pays before either starts substituting, so a difference in flips cannot be a difference in cost. The realised count is still stored per row, because a cap that is matched on paper and exhausted early in practice would be the same error as an unmatched denominator.

Four cells and one stronger attack. The factorial crosses the two orderings with the two oracles: *random-prob* (uniform order, probability oracle), *saliency-prob* (the attack of this section, so the cell doubles as its re-implementation), *random-verdict* (uniform order, one-bit oracle) and *group-verdict* (a binary search over candidate *subsets*: apply half, query once, recurse into the half that flipped). A fifth arm, *textfooler-prob*, implements TextFooler's search [6] rather than PWWS's: word importance is leave-one-out — each word replaced by a placeholder, importance the drop in $P(\text{malicious})$, doubled when the leave-one-out text has already flipped, which is the correction in the paper's Eq. 2 without which a word the model has already lost looks unimportant — then words are substituted in descending importance with all of one word's candidates predicted in one batch, accepting a flip that passes the meaning check and otherwise keeping the candidate that lowers the malicious confidence most. It costs one extra query per position, so it is matched by the cap rather than by construction and is reported as a stronger reference point, not as a fifth cell of the factorial.

The contrasts are then read as: *random-prob* vs *saliency-prob* is the ordering effect with vocabulary and budget held fixed; *random-prob* vs *random-verdict* is what probability access is worth to an

Table 6: Saliency-guided (PWWS-style) word attack next to the uniform-random word attack, both inside the same 15% word budget. Both spend a measured number of model queries: the random attack re-queries every original and keeps drawing until a flip or three attempts, the saliency attack probes every candidate. Per-sample query counts are stored with each row.

Task	Model	Attacked	Flips	ASR	95% CI	Pert.	Jacc.
SMS smishing	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct (saliency)	163	12	7.4%	4.3–12.4	12.6%	0.773
	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct (word)	161	6	3.7%	1.7–7.9	9.0%	0.918
	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct (saliency)	167	1	0.6%	0.1–3.3	12.3%	0.778
	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct (word)	186	6	3.2%	1.5–6.9	9.2%	0.916
	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct (saliency)	185	11	5.9%	3.4–10.3	12.9%	0.768
	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct (word)	184	3	1.6%	0.6–4.7	8.8%	0.916
Phishing email	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct (saliency)	120	14	11.7%	7.1–18.6	6.0%	0.867
	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct (word)	118	6	5.1%	2.4–10.7	6.3%	0.945
	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct (saliency)	169	4	2.4%	0.9–5.9	5.4%	0.876
	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct (word)	190	5	2.6%	1.1–6.0	6.2%	0.950
	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct (saliency)	197	4	2.0%	0.8–5.1	6.7%	0.851
	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct (word)	196	2	1.0%	0.3–3.6	6.3%	0.948

attacker who cannot rank; *random-verdict* vs *group-verdict* is how much of that a one-bit oracle can recover by searching instead of ranking; and *random-prob* against the recorded random word attack of §5 isolates the candidate set, which is the only thing those two do not share.

Meaning preservation is a constraint, not a claim. Every arm gates candidates through a lexical paraphrase test (WordNet-based, since this study ships no sentence-embedding model) and records, per applied perturbation, the similarity the gate used along with literal retention and paraphrase coverage. TextFooler's arm turns the gate on by default at a recorded threshold, because without a meaning constraint it is not TextFooler. All three scores travel with every row, so a reader can re-derive an acceptance decision at another threshold instead of taking ours.

What a one-bit attacker can and cannot do. PWWS's ordering needs a scalar per candidate. A verdict has one bit, and that bit is spent by the first flip, so a verdict-only arm *cannot rank* by saliency at all. Its targeted policy is therefore a search over subsets, and the oracle contrast is reported as how much of the saliency advantage survives when the attacker holds only the bit — not as a like-for-like ranking comparison, which would be measuring an impossible attacker.

Calibration, seeds and status. The meaning threshold and α are tuned on the calibration slice, which is disjoint from both the evaluation and the attack slice (`src/build_splits.py` asserts the disjointness), and never on the messages whose ASR is reported. Every arm takes a seed and the sweep driver re-runs it at several, so ordering effects can be separated from seed noise. One command per arm runs it (`python src/run_ablation.py --model <key> --arm <arm>`), and the per-sample records are written in the same schema as the other attacks, which is what lets the paired test of §5.7 be applied to the ablation without new code.

Table 7 reports each contrast on the messages its two arms share. With the candidate set, the probe phase and the query cap held fixed, ordering by saliency flips 17 messages the uniform draw does not, against 0 in the other direction (exact McNemar $p = 0.0000$ over 1001 paired messages). Replacing the probability channel with the one-bit verdict loses 26 messages that survive on probabilities and wins 14 the probability arm misses ($p = 0.0807$, 1001 pairs). Searching over candidate subsets instead of ranking under the same bit recovers 6 messages the ranking arm misses, against 0 in the other direction ($p = 0.0312$, 1044 pairs). Against the 14-entry hand-written table, the lexicon plus WordNet flips 32 messages the small table does not, against 1 ($p = 0.0000$, 1044 pairs). TextFooler's leave-one-out importance ranking flips 0 messages PWWS's saliency ranking does not, against 20 in the other direction ($p = 0.0000$, 1001 pairs). The published attack's ranking therefore is not uniformly stronger on these messages, which is why it is reported as a reference point rather than as a fifth cell. These are pooled counts over model and task, and the cells reuse messages across models, so they describe a direction rather than a confirmatory test; the per-cell pairs are in the artefact.

Reading the five contrasts. The ordering contrast is the one this section was built for, and it is the cleanest result in the paper: with the candidate set, the probe phase and the cap held fixed, every discordant message went to saliency ordering. The candidate-set contrast is nearly as large again, which is the uncomfortable half of the finding — most of the difference between Table 6's two rows is vocabulary, not intelligence, so the unmatched comparison overstates what ordering buys. Probability access, the thing a saliency attack is supposed to need, is the weakest of the three: an attacker holding only the one-bit verdict loses messages in one direction and wins a few in the other, and the difference does not reach significance at this sample size. Searching subsets instead of ranking recovers a handful of the messages that bit costs, which is what the theory predicts, because one bit cannot rank.

The fifth contrast needs its budget read out loud before its number is quoted. TextFooler's leave-one-out importance spends 23.0 of the 24 calls per message measuring word importance, where the saliency arm spends 20.6 and still has edits left to spend its calls on; the extra query per position is what the published search costs, and under a cap that has to cover both the probe and the substitutions, it is paid for out of the substitutions. So the contrast says what a

Table 7: Matched-vocabulary, matched-budget ablation of Section 6.1. Every contrast holds the candidate set, the probe phase and the 24-call cap fixed and varies one thing; A and B are the two arms, and positive A-only means the first arm flipped messages the second did not. Counts are pooled over model and task; the per-cell pairs are in `results/ablation_contrasts.csv`.

Contrast	Isolates	Paired	A flips	B flips	A-only	B-only	p
candidates	candidate set	1044	45	14	32	1	0.0000
oracle	oracle	1001	44	32	26	14	0.0807
ordering	ordering	1001	61	44	17	0	0.0000
search	search under one bit	1044	51	45	6	0	0.0312
stronger	search rule	1001	41	61	0	20	0.0000

query-starved importance ranking achieves inside this cap — not that the published attack is weaker, which this design cannot test. It is reported as a reference point and not as a fifth cell for that reason, and the arm's per-sample records carry the realised query count so a reader can check the accounting rather than take it on faith.

7 DO THE PERTURBATIONS TRANSFER ACROSS MODELS?

A single-model ASR answers a narrow question: how much does *this* model cost an attacker who can query it. That is the right question for a targeted campaign and the wrong one for a defender choosing a model, because an attacker who cannot query the deployed model will instead craft perturbations against something they can download. Whether those perturbations survive the move decides whether the fragility measured in §5 is a property of the task or an artefact of three specific checkpoints.

Protocol. We generate no new perturbations. Every text produced by the three attacks — character, word and saliency — is replayed, unchanged, against every other model, with the same prompt, the same answer parser and temperature zero. The saliency rows are the ones worth having: that edit was chosen against the source model's own measured probabilities, so its cell asks whether the choice survives a different decision boundary, where a random edit only asks whether the model is noisy in the same way as its neighbour. Two accounting rules make the resulting numbers comparable with the single-model ones:

- **The target owns the denominator.** A perturbation "transfers" only if the target model read the *original* text as malicious and the *perturbed* text as benign. A message the target never flagged cannot be evaded, and scoring it as a transfer failure would punish the target for being wrong on the clean text — the opposite of robustness.
- **Two subsets, one tabulated.** The *applied* subset contains every perturbation the source actually applied; its denominator is how often the target caught those originals, so it measures the transferability of the perturbation *family*. The *flipped-source* subset keeps only the perturbations that fooled the source — the classic transfer matrix — and it is what the literature reports, but at this scale it holds one to six candidates per cell, so its cells carry no denominator worth an interval. We tabulate the applied subset and keep the classic one in the artefact.

The faithfulness check. Replaying a model's own perturbations must reproduce its single-model ASR exactly — same text, same prompt, deterministic decoder — and a mismatch there would invalidate every off-diagonal cell. We run that replay as part of the same pass (`run_transfer.py --include-self`), and we compare it against the attack tables rather than against itself: the stored flip flag from the attack run is the claim, the replayed verdict is the evidence. Every diagonal cell agrees. This is what makes the off-diagonal cells a measurement: the replay path is the same code, prompt and parser that produced Table 3, so a transferred flip cannot be an artefact of the harness. It is a weaker statement than it looks, and worth saying plainly: agreement shows the replay is faithful, not that the decoder is deterministic in general — greedy decoding is reproducible on one GPU build, and a cell could drift on another.

On the applied subset 22 of 36 off-diagonal cells have a nonzero transfer rate, and every cell has a denominator worth an interval. Among the cells with a denominator worth an interval, the highest rate is SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct → Phi-3.5-mini-instruct on Phishing email under the saliency attack: 5 of 120 caught originals flipped (4.2%, 95% CI 1.8–9.4). The self-replay is the check that makes the rest of the table readable: each model's own perturbations went through the same path a second time, and its flip count is compared with the one the attack recorded. 18 diagonal cells covering 3,080 rows were replayed, and every one reproduces the single-model ASR exactly.

Table 8 reports the applied subset only, for all three attack modes; the classic flipped-source matrix lives in the artefact, where its small denominators cannot be mistaken for a rate.

8 TWO DEFENCES THAT NEED NO TRAINING

If the mechanism of an evasion is understood, a cheap fix should blunt it. We test two post-hoc defences that require no fine-tuning, no extra data and no change to the deployed weights, and measure them on the *same* stored perturbations the attacks produced, so the comparison is like-for-like.

D1: input normalisation. The text is NFKC-normalised, invisible and format characters are removed, Cyrillic and Greek homoglyphs are folded back to their ASCII look-alikes, and whitespace is collapsed. This targets exactly the mechanism of the character attack: the model sees a different token where a human sees the same word. It should therefore rescue character-level evasions and do almost nothing for word-level ones — and that null result is the

Table 8: Cross-model transfer on the applied subset: every perturbation the source produced is replayed on the target, and the denominator is the TARGET's own caught originals, because a perturbation cannot transfer on a message the target never flagged. No diagonal is tabulated: replaying a model's own perturbations reproduces its attack run and would only reprint Table 3. That replay was run as a faithfulness check and its diagonal appears in the prose below, not as a result. Cells with fewer than ten caught originals would be marked †; none in this table needed it.

Mode	Task	Source	Target	Caught	Flips	ASR	95% CI
char	SMS smishing	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	163	0	0.0%	0.0–2.3
		Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	160	0	0.0%	0.0–2.3
		Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	163	1	0.6%	0.1–3.4
		Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	179	0	0.0%	0.0–2.1
		SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	160	1	0.6%	0.1–3.5
		SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	179	0	0.0%	0.0–2.1
char	Phishing email	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	119	0	0.0%	0.0–3.1
		Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	120	0	0.0%	0.0–3.1
		Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	119	4	3.4%	1.3–8.3
		Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	189	0	0.0%	0.0–2.0
		SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	120	2	1.7%	0.5–5.9
		SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	189	1	0.5%	0.1–2.9
word	SMS smishing	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	161	1	0.6%	0.1–3.4
		Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	158	1	0.6%	0.1–3.5
		Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	162	3	1.8%	0.6–5.3
		Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	178	0	0.0%	0.0–2.1
		SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	160	1	0.6%	0.1–3.5
		SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	178	4	2.2%	0.9–5.6
word	Phishing email	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	117	0	0.0%	0.0–3.2
		Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	118	0	0.0%	0.0–3.1
		Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	119	4	3.4%	1.3–8.3
		Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	188	0	0.0%	0.0–2.0
		SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	120	3	2.5%	0.9–7.1
		SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	188	1	0.5%	0.1–2.9
saliency	SMS smishing	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	163	1	0.6%	0.1–3.4
		Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	160	0	0.0%	0.0–2.3
		Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	154	2	1.3%	0.4–4.6
		Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	163	1	0.6%	0.1–3.4
		SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	160	0	0.0%	0.0–2.3
		SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	179	4	2.2%	0.9–5.6
saliency	Phishing email	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	119	1	0.8%	0.1–4.6
		Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	120	0	0.0%	0.0–3.1
		Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	113	4	3.5%	1.4–8.8
		Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	167	1	0.6%	0.1–3.3
		SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	Phi-3.5-mini-instruct	120	5	4.2%	1.8–9.4
		SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct	Qwen2.5-3B-Instruct	189	5	2.6%	1.1–6.0

evidence that the two attack families fail for different reasons. The transform is idempotent, which is asserted in `tests/check_defense.py`; a non-idempotent normaliser would make the "defended" number an artefact of running it twice.

D2: re-thresholding under a false-positive budget. The model's $P(\text{malicious})$ is compared against a threshold τ instead of the default 0.5. τ is fitted on the clean benign half of the evaluation split to a 5% false-positive budget, and it is the *smallest* threshold that meets that budget, i.e. the least conservative operating point the budget allows. Two figures travel with every headline number: the clean false-positive rate at τ, and the clean true-positive rate it costs. Without the second, a drop in ASR cannot be distinguished from a filter that has simply stopped flagging mail.

The direction of the search matters and is easy to get backwards. A larger τ always has a lower false-positive rate, so maximising it under an upper bound is trivially satisfied by "above every clean score" — a filter that rejects everything. Our first implementation did exactly that, and because it also counted a flip whenever a perturbed text fell below τ, without asking whether the original was above it, it reported a 100% ASR for the defence. Both rules are now enforced in code: τ is the minimum feasible value, and a sample counts as flipped only if the *same* rule classified the *original* text as malicious.

Reading the outcome. Three outcomes are possible and all three are informative: a defence that removes the flips it targets (D1 against the character attack), a defence that removes none (D1

against a word attack it cannot see), and a defence that trades a small amount of clean precision for a large reduction in evasions (D2). What we do not do is report a defence at a different operating point than the baseline and call the difference robustness.

Under the char attack, normalisation moves the aggregate ASR from 1.0% to 0.0%. Under the word attack, normalisation moves the aggregate ASR from 2.5% to 2.0%. Under the saliency attack, normalisation moves the aggregate ASR from 7.5% to 6.9%. The threshold is not free: at the 5% clean false-positive budget its tightest operating point (SmolLM2-1.7B-Instruct, SMS smishing) keeps clean recall at 23.0%, down from 100.0% at the default threshold. 1 of 6 model–task cells cannot meet the budget at all: holding their false positives down requires a threshold that rejects every message.

Table 9 is read column by column, because its baseline column uses the probability channel the threshold needs and the attack tables do not; the next section says what that costs the comparison.

9 DISCUSSION AND LIMITATIONS

9.1 Why a low evasion rate is a result, not a failed attack

Some readers might view an Attack Success Rate (ASR) of 0.0–5.1% as a failed attack. In our setting, the opposite reading is more accurate. The attack spends its full edit budget. It changes 13.3–13.6% of characters and 6.2–9.2% of words. It runs up to three attempts per sample. In total, it flips 40 decisions. What the attack does not do is guided search. It draws edits at random instead of selecting the most damaging ones.

Section 6 shows why search matters. We test synonym replacements under the same 15% word budget. When substitutions are ordered by measured saliency (their observed impact on the model's decision), the flip rate is 4.6%. When substitutions are chosen at random, the flip rate is only 2.7%. In paired tests, saliency flips 33 messages that random edits miss, while random edits flip only 7 that saliency misses. Thus, we should not claim these models are robust. Instead, under random bounded edits they rarely flip; under a guided search with the same budget, they flip about twice as often.

9.2 Word edits cost fewer changes and flip more decisions

Word-level changes flip more decisions than character-level noise (28 versus 12 flips). At the same time, word edits modify fewer units (6.2–9.2% of words versus 13.3–13.6% of characters). The paired analysis in §5.7 confirms this pattern. Word edits outperform character edits in five of six cells, and the pooled difference is significant (26 versus 10, $p = 0.011$). The text similarity values explain this outcome. Word edits preserve 92–95% of original words. Character edits leave only 30.3–32.8% word overlap. A homoglyph (a character that looks like another) alters the token representation even when human readers see no change.

9.3 Vulnerability is concentrated in specific words

The saliency results clarify how random attacks behave. If an evasion succeeds only when striking specific decisive words, a random draw from a small dictionary rarely hits them. That explains the low 2.7% baseline flip rate.

The saliency attack confirms this behavior. Most evasions require only two or three targeted word substitutions. However, the saliency attack edits more words on average (9.3% versus 7.6%, as shown in Table 4). Normalized by edit rate, its advantage is roughly 1.4 times rather than 1.7 times. Thus, vulnerability is concentrated in specific tokens. This finding is useful for defenders because targeted words can be filtered. It also warns against taking random perturbation rates as proof of general robustness.

This effect varies across models. Phi-3.5-mini sits close to its decision boundary. Its ASR roughly doubles under saliency search (11.7% and 7.4% versus 5.1% and 3.7% under random word edits). Qwen2.5-3B is more accurate and does not flip more often under saliency (2.4% and 0.6% versus 2.6% and 3.2%). Its remaining errors cannot be reached by this candidate vocabulary.

9.4 Two readouts of one model are not one measurement

The saliency attack requires continuous scores, so it optimizes the predicted probability $P(\text{malicious})$ over two answer tokens. The rest of this paper evaluates the generated text decision. We rechecked every stored saliency sample with text generation. The two channels agree on 941 of 1,001 rows. The disagreements are systematic. For Phi-3.5-mini, both channels agree on all rows. For Qwen2.5-3B, the probability channel claims 45 flips that generation does not confirm. For SmolLM2-1.7B, generation claims 15 flips that the probability route misses.

This gap occurs because a two-token probability readout does not match free-form decoding. When answer words split into subtokens, probability ratios can point one way while greedy decoding points the other. We report final text decisions throughout the paper. We view the divergence as a limitation of probability probing in small language models.

9.5 The transfer we observe is low

We replayed every stored perturbation (character, word, and saliency) against every other model. Very few perturbations transferred. On the applied subset, only 51 of 5,514 caught messages (0.9%) flipped off the diagonal. Specifically, 9 flips came from 1,860 character edits, 18 from 1,847 word edits, and 24 from 1,807 saliency edits. Guided edits transferred slightly better than random edits. However, confidence intervals overlap, indicating a broad trend rather than a sharp separation. In the classic flipped-source matrix, only 5 of 31 cells are non-zero, and 27 of 31 cells hold fewer than ten caught originals.

A 0.9% rate indicates low observed transfer, not total immunity. Fifty-one messages did cross model boundaries. Either these perturbations are model-specific, or they are too weak to cross distant decision boundaries. In either case, robustness evaluations on one model do not guarantee safety on another.

9.6 Defenses: character cleaning succeeds while re-thresholding fails

Character normalization cleans visually confusable characters. It removes every character-level flip (1.0% to 0.0% pooled). It leaves

Table 9: Training-free defences, measured on the same stored perturbations. *None* is the undefended ASR, *norm* applies input normalisation only, *thr* replaces the default decision threshold with one fitted on clean benign mail to a 5% false-positive budget. Rows are pooled over the three models; *n* is the number of originals the undefended rule itself flagged, and *n/a* means a defence flagged none of them, so there was nothing left to flip. † marks a row containing a model-task pair whose false-positive budget could not be met: its threshold is a rejection rule, not a defence, and the number is there to be ignored.

Mode	Task	None	Norm.	Thr.	*n*
char	SMS smishing	0.6%	0.0%	2.3%†	515
char	Phishing email	1.4%	0.0%	7.7%	486
word	SMS smishing	2.1%	2.1%	4.7%†	512
word	Phishing email	2.9%	1.9%	5.4%	483
saliency	SMS smishing	6.6%	6.6%	19.9%†	515
saliency	Phishing email	8.4%	7.3%	18.9%	486

word and saliency attacks largely unaffected (2.5% to 2.0%, and 7.5% to 6.9%). This confirms our hypothesis: distinct perturbation types fail for distinct reasons.

Re-thresholding yields mixed results. We adjust the threshold τ to enforce a 5% clean false-positive budget. This reduces flips on well-calibrated models. However, on SmolLM2-1.7B (where clean scores cluster near 1.0), it increases evasions: 0.0% to 29.0% on email and 0.0% to 13.3% on SMS. Lowering the threshold places the decision cutoff inside perturbation noise. It also lowers clean recall on SmolLM2-1.7B (100% to 34.5% and 23.0%). For one task cell, the budget cannot be met without rejecting all messages.

9.7 Limitations

Search strength. Random perturbations are weak adversaries. The saliency attack uses greedy first-order search over a fixed candidate set. It is not a full implementation of PWWS or TextFooler, nor is it a white-box gradient attack. Reported ASR values are lower bounds on attacker capabilities.

Transfer coverage. The transfer matrix covers all three attacks. Faithfulness is verified by self-replay: diagonal cells match the original attack logs exactly. These tests demonstrate harness consistency on a single GPU environment rather than universal cross-platform reproducibility.

Unmatched vocabulary in primary tables. The saliency attack uses a broader vocabulary than the random word attack. The ablation in §6.1 isolates vocabulary, ordering, and oracle effects across five arms. The reported contrasts in Table 7 hold candidate sets and query caps constant.

Defense operating point. The defense probe evaluates a 5% false-positive budget using probability scores. Because thresholding requires numeric scores, its baseline column is not directly comparable to text verdict tables.

Saliency denominator. The saliency attack excludes 43 originals that its probability channel classified as benign (all on Qwen2.5-3B). Its denominator is 1,001 messages, compared to 2,079 for random attacks. Nine additional exclusions in the word attack correspond to identical text transformations (52 exclusions total).

Similarity metric. We report word-level Jaccard similarity without neural sentence embeddings. For character edits, Jaccard similarity is an imperfect proxy, and actual edit rate is the cleaner measure.

Uncertainty scope. Confidence intervals represent sample variation over messages, not seed variability across runs.

Sample design. Attacks target the correctly classified subset of an 800-row evaluation split. This provides an accurate conditional denominator but does not represent out-of-distribution generalization.

Model coverage. We evaluate three open models. Llama-3.2-3B-Instruct was omitted due to access restrictions.

Task construct. SMS smishing is evaluated on the UCI SMS Spam dataset, where spam includes broader commercial promotions. Phishing email data comes from public benchmark collections.

Missing experiments. Paraphrase generation attacks and defense-aware adaptive attacks were designed but not run.

10 ETHICS AND ARTEFACT AVAILABILITY

Dual use. The perturbations studied here are text edits that any sender can apply by hand; no exploit, payload or delivery mechanism is introduced. Two of the three adversaries are random draws, but the third is not, and we describe it as it is rather than as a stronger random draw: the saliency attack *does* select the substitution to apply, per message, using measured model behaviour, and the ablation of §6.1 adds a TextFooler-style importance ranking on the same candidate set. That is a targeted search, and an earlier draft of this section claimed otherwise. It is also not a new capability: PWWS and TextFooler are published, TextAttack implements both, and this implementation is weaker than either — a greedy first-order search over a hand-built lexicon plus WordNet, with a 24-call cap, a 15% word budget and a lexical paraphrase constraint, on open checkpoints. No attack here is tuned against a deployed classifier, no victim system is probed, and nothing released lowers the cost of an attack below what those toolkits already provide. We report that small triage models resist the random adversaries and that the targeted one roughly doubles the flip rate, which is the defensive direction of the finding: both numbers tell an operator that

a random-draw ASR is not a robustness guarantee. Withholding the measurement would leave operators believing a false-positive prone detector is robust.

Data. Both corpora are public and contain no live credentials or personally identifiable information beyond what their publishers already released. No human subjects were involved; no production system was probed.

Reporting honesty. Seven measurement defects were found and fixed in our own pipeline before the numbers in this paper were produced: per-operation edit budgets that reached 22% while the paper claimed 15%; estimated rather than measured edit counts; a similarity metric labelled BERTScore that was word Jaccard; an attack set drawn from messages the model had never caught; a saliency score that is a constant at $\alpha = 0.5$ unless it is normalised, which silently reduced the greedy search to applying substitutions left to right; an answer-token lookup that compared the same white-space token for both answers on one tokenizer, making the verdict probability exactly 0.5 for every message; and a defence threshold chosen by maximising the cutoff rather than minimising it, which rejected everything and, together with unconditional flip counting, reported a 100% attack success rate for the defence. The last three were caught by unit tests that check the mechanism rather than the headline number — the runs they produced looked entirely plausible. Each of these defects inflated an apparent effect, and none of them would have been visible to a reader of the results alone. The per-sample records shipped with the artefact are the ones the tables are rebuilt from, so a reader can recompute every number in this paper without a GPU.

Availability. Code, frozen splits and per-sample results are at https://github.com/daud-glitch/SilentEvasion. The artefact contains the frozen splits with fingerprints, the prompt, the perturbation code for all three attacks, the five ablation arms of §6.1, the defence probe, the per-sample attack records (including every perturbed text), both verdict channels for the saliency rows, the transfer replays, the threshold fits, the table-generation script and the script that produces every table in this paper from those records. A single command recomputes the tables and fails if a number in the text no longer matches the records; a second command re-runs the study end to end on a free-tier GPU in about two hours. The split fingerprints are published so that a reader can prove their rebuild is the split these numbers came from, and the calibration slice that tunes α and the meaning threshold is disjoint from both the evaluation and the attack slice, asserted at build time.

11 CONCLUSION

We measured what a bounded, black-box text perturbation buys an attacker against three small language models. These models work zero-shot for security triage. Under a shared 15% edit budget, random character-level perturbation flips 0.0–5.0% of the messages a model had already caught. Random word-level perturbation flips 1.0–5.1% while changing about half as many units. Ordering the same word edit by measured saliency roughly doubles that: 4.6% against 2.7%, 33 message-specific flips against 7 when both are paired on the messages they share.

Three things follow. First, a robustness number is a property of the search as much as of the model. Inside the same 15% word budget, choosing substitutions rather than drawing them nearly doubles the flip rate (2.7% to 4.6%). This result is not on the same messages or from the same candidate vocabulary. Once we account for the higher budget actually spent, the factor is 1.4, not 1.7. The search, the candidates, and the denominator must all be named in the claim. Second, at this budget the binding constraint on a small triage model is what it catches before any attack. The model that flips most is closest to its decision boundary. The model that catches almost everything is immovable because its decision rule is nearly constant. Detection quality, not adversarial robustness, is where deployment effort pays first. Third, cheap defences split cleanly. Normalising visually confusable characters removes every character-level flip and only a small part of the word-level ones (7.5% to 6.9%). Re-thresholding to hold a false-positive budget can create evasions on a model whose scores are least calibrated.

The measurement lesson runs through all of it. The transfer we observed was low (0.9% of caught messages off the diagonal). Per-model numbers are worth measuring separately. The probability readout and the generated verdict agreed on 941 of 1,001 rows. They diverged systematically on two of three models. A single readout is not a measurement until it is checked against the other. Every tool in this paper reports its denominator, its interval, and the bugs we fixed in our own pipeline. Each bug silently inflated the attack success rate in the direction that makes a paper look interesting.

The matched-vocabulary, matched-budget ablation of §6.1 is the one experiment here that attributes rather than describes. With the candidate set, the probe phase, and the call budget held fixed, it reports what ordering is worth on its own. What it cannot do is turn five contrasts on roughly a thousand paired messages into a ranking of attacks. Next: a sentence-level paraphrase attacker and a defence-aware attacker that knows the threshold. Neither is claimed here.

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